MODULE 6

Module 6: Designs & Freestyle

6 techniques · 18 video lessons



In this guide

A foundation before flair

What you will learn

The three principles of every design

Protect the skin

1. Design basics and tools

2. Line art with the trimmer

3. 3D freestyle

4. Anime designs

5. Shading and gradients

6. Client consultation and design aftercare

Next step

> *Designs and freestyle are where a barber's artistry is on full display. A sharp line, a smooth shadow or a detailed illustration shaved into hair can turn a good haircut into a signature piece. This module builds the skills step by step, from tools and planning to advanced techniques.*

A foundation before flair

Great designs sit on top of a clean haircut. Before attempting any pattern, make sure your fade is smooth, your edges are crisp and your clipper control is steady. A design applied to an uneven base will always look uneven.

What you will learn

1. Design basics and tools: planning, placement and equipment.
2. Line art with the trimmer: straight lines, curves and symmetry.
3. 3D freestyle: creating depth with shadow and highlight.
4. Anime designs: translating illustrated styles into hair.
5. Shading and gradients: blending tones smoothly.
6. Client consultation and design aftercare: agreeing on the design and maintaining it.

The three principles of every design

- **Planning:** sketch the design, decide on placement and confirm it with the client before you touch the clipper.
- **Control:** small, deliberate movements with a firm grip and a stable stance beat speed every time.
- **Cleanliness:** clean lines and clean tools produce clean results and keep skin safe.

> **Practice off the client**
>
> Practice new designs on mannequin heads, pig-skin practice mats or even paper before attempting them on a person. Never test a new design on a client without their informed agreement.

Protect the skin

Detail work often uses trimmers and razors close to the skin. Always use clean, properly disinfected tools and a fresh single-use blade where a razor is involved. Pause if the client is uncomfortable, and avoid shaving over irritated, broken or inflamed skin.

> **Hands steady, mind clear**
>
> Do not rush a design. A mistake in a shaved pattern cannot be undone, so plan carefully, take breaks to step back and view the whole head, and be honest with clients about what is realistic for their hair type and density.

Treat every design as a collaboration. Your client's preferences, hair characteristics and daily routine all shape what will look best. With patient practice you will build both your technical skill and your personal style.

> **About the video lessons**
>
> This module lists 18 curated public video lessons from experienced barbers, linked from their original channels. They belong to their creators and links can change over time. Every technique also has complete written steps, so you can follow it without the videos.

#	TECHNIQUE	VIDEOS
1	Design basics and tools	3
2	Line art with the trimmer	3
3	3D freestyle	3
4	Anime designs	3
5	Shading and gradients	3
6	Client consultation and design aftercare	3

1. Design basics and tools

> *Choose the right tools and plan a design before the first stroke.*

Estimated practice time: 30-45 minutes

Tools you need

- Detail trimmer
- Foil shaver or edging tool as appropriate
- Fine-toothed comb
- Mannequin or practice head
- Pencil or washable marker
- Neck strip and cape
- Mirror for checking symmetry

Step by step

1. Start with a clean, finished haircut. The design sits on top of a smooth base.
2. Gather and inspect your tools. Make sure the trimmer blade is clean, oiled and properly aligned.
3. Study the reference image. Break the design into simple shapes: lines, curves, circles and shadows.

4. Sketch the design on paper at the scale it will appear on the head, noting where it sits relative to the ear, hairline and part.
5. Decide on placement with the client and confirm it in the mirror. A design that is a little too high or low can look off.
6. Mark guide points with a washable marker or by lightly outlining with the trimmer, if the client agrees.
7. Stabilize your hand by resting your pinky or the side of your hand on the client's head. This keeps the line steady.
8. Work from the outline inward and step back often to compare both sides.
9. Clean up edges, brush off clippings and check from all angles.
10. Take a photo (with permission) to review your work and track improvement.

Common mistakes

- Starting without a plan or reference.
- Using dull or poorly aligned trimmers.
- Holding the tool too tightly and drifting.
- Not resting the hand for stability.
- Skipping the client's approval of placement.

Practice drill

Draw five simple shapes on a mannequin with a washable marker, then trace them with a trimmer using no clipper motion. Aim for steady, even edges.

> **Safety note**
>
> Use only clean, disinfected tools and avoid shaving over irritated skin. Stop immediately if the client feels discomfort.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Barber Design Tutorial 🪒✨ STEP-BY-STEP 📚 Voiceover w/ ASMR Sounds 🎓 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v6mSFq-6I8U	HowToFade101	Step-by-step barber design tutorial for beginners
Design Tutorial for Beginner Barbers: Easy to Follow Instructions https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=totl4ZoxJF0	Barber Style Directory	Easy-to-follow design instructions for beginner barbers
Freestyle design tutorial for beginners https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Oc7yr5Mljs	ClutchTheBarber	Freestyle design basics for beginners

2. Line art with the trimmer

> *Create straight lines, smooth curves and symmetrical patterns with a detail trimmer.*

Estimated practice time: 30-60 minutes

Tools you need

- Detail trimmer with a sharp, aligned blade
- Fine comb
- Washable marker
- Mannequin head
- Neck strip
- Soft brush

Step by step

1. Wet or lightly dampen the hair if needed for cleaner lines, or work dry as your preference and hair type allow.
2. Mark the starting and ending points of each line with a washable marker or a light trimmer touch.
3. Hold the trimmer like a pencil, with the blade angled so only the corner touches the skin.
4. Pull straight lines in one smooth motion, rather than stopping and restarting, which creates steps.
5. For curves, rotate your wrist and forearm together, not just your fingers, to keep the curve fluid.
6. Use the corner of the blade for sharp turns, and the flat edge for broader sections.
7. Check symmetry by comparing both sides in the mirror, then fix small differences by tapering the line, not widening it.
8. Clean up stray hairs with a soft brush and re-check the outline in different lighting.
9. Finish with a light skin-care step such as a soothing product if appropriate.

Common mistakes

- Stopping and starting mid-line.
- Pressing too hard, causing skin irritation.
- Using only fingers instead of the wrist and forearm.
- Cutting too deep early and having no room to correct.
- Rushing symmetry checks.

Practice drill

On a mannequin, fill a page of parallel lines and curves. Repeat until you can draw lines of equal length and spacing in a single motion.

> **Safety note**
> Use light pressure, clean tools and no shaving over broken skin. Watch for redness and stop if irritation appears.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Hair Line art tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vwxOTilGVuk	The Barber Today	Hair line art tutorial with trimmer
How to Cut Sharp Part Lines 🔥 Barber Hair Designs and Parts https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rE9Ds7VzfcQ	Seancutshair	Cutting sharp part lines and hair designs
Haircut in process fading, how to create haircuts and lines designs https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Zv3vDqIq4zI	Born2fade	Creating line designs while fading

3. 3D freestyle

> *Create the illusion of depth in a design using shadows, highlights and layered tones.*

Estimated practice time: 1-2 hours

Tools you need

- Detail trimmer
- Foil shaver or fine edging tool
- Clipper with a range of guard lengths
- Blending brush
- Fine comb
- Reference image
- Washable marker

Step by step

1. Study how light falls on the object you want to draw. Identify the lightest areas, the midtones and the darkest shadows.
2. Map those zones lightly on the head with a washable marker or a faint trimmer outline.
3. Start with the base fade or gradient so there is a smooth range of tones to work with.
4. Add the darkest shadow areas first by leaving more hair length where you want depth, or by working the opposite way depending on the style.
5. Build midtones by gradually reducing length with a lighter touch, keeping edges soft where shapes curve away from the light.
6. Use the foil shaver or trimmer to add crisp highlights where light would reflect.
7. Pause often and step back to look at the entire head from several angles; 3D effects can look different up close.
8. Refine edges, blend any harsh transitions with a brush and trimmer, and clean up the surrounding skin.
9. Compare to the reference and fine-tune.

Common mistakes

- Ignoring a consistent light source.
- Making shadows too abrupt.
- Over-cutting highlights so they cannot be corrected.
- Working too close without stepping back.
- Attempting complex scenes before mastering simple shapes.

Practice drill

Draw a sphere, a cube and a cylinder on paper with shading, then replicate them on a mannequin using clipper work. Repeat until each looks convincingly three-dimensional.

> **Safety note**
>
> Detail work needs patience and clean tools. Avoid pressing hard on skin and stop if the client becomes uncomfortable.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Freestyle 3D Haircut Design https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ayVCYpra7C0	Dorian Barber	Freestyle 3D haircut design demonstration
How to: Do The Highborn 3D HAIRTATTOO (step by step) HD tutorial + Fade https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pg1699idTow	The Handsome Black Sheep	3D hair tattoo step-by-step with a fade
Lightning Flash Hair Tattoo https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r8_rRworJVY	TheExtremebarber	Lightning flash hair tattoo design

4. Anime designs

> *Translate illustrated anime-style lines and shapes into clean hair designs.*

Estimated practice time: 1.5-3 hours

Tools you need

- Detail trimmer
- Foil shaver
- Fine comb
- Reference illustration
- Washable marker
- Practice head
- Neck strip

Step by step

1. Pick a simple design to start, with bold outlines and limited detail, since anime art relies on clear shapes.
2. Break the illustration into major parts: outline, eyes, hair shapes, and shading.
3. Scale the design to fit the area of the head, keeping in mind the curve of the skull, which can distort proportions.
4. Transfer the main outline to the head using a washable marker, checking it from the front and side.
5. Cut the outline first with the trimmer, using the corner of the blade for sharp points and narrow lines.
6. Add the larger shapes next, such as hair strands or clothing, filling with lighter or darker tones as in the reference.
7. Detail the smaller features last, like eyes and highlights, using light, controlled strokes.
8. Check symmetry and proportion, stepping back to see the overall design.
9. Clean edges, brush the head and review the finished work from different angles.

Common mistakes

- Choosing a design too complex for current skill.
- Ignoring the curve of the head.
- Cutting the details first.
- Skipping the outline stage.
- Losing proportion because you did not step back.

Practice drill

Recreate three simple anime-style characters on paper at head scale. Then transfer one to a mannequin and cut it using only the trimmer's corner and flat edge.

> **Safety note**
>
> Work only on healthy skin and ask the client to tell you immediately about any discomfort. Keep tools clean.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
anime hair styling tutorial😋 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=18J0oDnL30g	Ryan Lin	Anime hair styling tutorial
How to get Anime Hair - in partnership with @based https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rdF1VFv2cSE	Stash	How to get anime hair, explained
3 Anime inspired hairstyles 📍 SAN JOSE, CA 🏈 Click the link in my bio to book with https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EeGqp9QlmeM	NYC Barber | Patrick Ho	Three anime-inspired hairstyles shown on clients

5. Shading and gradients

> *Blend tones smoothly from dark to light, adding dimension to any design.*

Estimated practice time: 45-90 minutes

Tools you need

- Clipper
- Guards in several lengths
- Detail trimmer
- Blending brush
- Fine comb
- Mannequin head
- Neck strip

Step by step

1. Plan the gradient direction, such as top to bottom or center outward, based on the design.
2. Start with a longer guard where the darkest tone will be and work outward to shorter lengths.
3. Use a flicking motion at the end of each stroke to soften the line between lengths.
4. Move to the next shorter guard, overlapping slightly into the previous zone, and repeat.
5. Comb the hair against the grain to lift any missed hairs and check the blend.
6. Use the clipper with the guard off, or the trimmer, for the lightest areas, keeping the skin smooth and clean.
7. Fine-tune harsh lines using a lever or lifting technique, if needed, with very small movements.
8. Step back and view from different angles; look for any visible bands or patches.
9. Do a final pass with a brush, clean the skin and style the hair.

Common mistakes

- Using too large a jump between guards.
- Stopping the stroke abruptly, leaving a line.
- Not overlapping zones.
- Working only in one lighting condition.
- Skipping the comb check.

Practice drill

On a mannequin or practice mat, create a five-step gradient with clean, invisible transitions. Repeat until you can do it without lines.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep blades clean and aligned, avoid pressing hard and watch for skin irritation during close work.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Freestyle taper design #barber #fade #freestyle #hair #taper #skintaper #fadegame #skinfadehaircut https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kaZOHVCbYWg	Jason Dang	Freestyle taper design with shading
GradientXAmighetti Gradient Barber Course Day 1 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xPts_lqqEoU	GRADIENT	Gradient barbering course lesson, day one
Cross Graduation Tutorial | Pillars Of Hair | Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XRqIM-rjXpQ	Pillars Of Hair - By NoLabel	Cross graduation technique tutorial

6. Client consultation and design aftercare

> *Agree on a design that suits the client and teach them how to maintain it.*

Estimated practice time: 15-20 minutes

Tools you need

- Reference images or sketch pad
- Mirror
- Consent and notes form
- Washable marker
- Aftercare sheet
- Camera or phone with permission

Step by step

1. Ask about the client's lifestyle, work or school rules and how often they can visit. Some designs need frequent maintenance.
2. Check for skin conditions, allergies, scars or irritation in the area. Do not work over broken or inflamed skin.
3. Look at hair type, density and growth patterns. These determine how well a design will hold and how it will grow out.
4. Review the reference images together and agree on size, placement and level of detail.
5. Explain what is realistic for their hair. Some designs will not show clearly on fine, thin or very curly hair.
6. Sketch or mark the design on the head before cutting and confirm approval in the mirror.

7. Make clear that shaved designs are temporary. They grow out, and the client should avoid scratching or picking at the area.
8. Give aftercare advice: avoid harsh products on freshly shaved skin, keep the scalp clean, and schedule touch-ups at a suitable interval.
9. Take photos with the client's permission to track your portfolio.

Common mistakes

- Starting without agreeing on the design.
- Ignoring skin conditions.
- Promising results the hair type cannot deliver.
- Forgetting to explain how long it will last.
- Posting photos without permission.

Practice drill

Role-play a full consultation with a friend using three reference images. Practice explaining what is possible, what is not, and how to maintain the design.

> **Safety note**
>
> Never shave over irritated or broken skin. Use clean, disinfected tools and a new blade for any razor work. Ask for permission before taking photos.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
'Haircut Consultation' finding the right length for my client https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZGg5QhBOc8c	Sam Rascals	Haircut consultation: choosing the right length for the client
Barber Consultations: You Have Been Doing It Completely WRONG! This Is The Right Way https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bmiBxF9f2IY	Chris Ashok	Barber consultations done right
How to Master Client Consultations in 8 Simple Steps https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tpi4rIi1OkU	Glassbox Education	Client consultations in eight simple steps

Next step

Practice each technique on a mannequin head until you can repeat it with clean results, then move to the next module.